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ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

GST 105: Humanities - Art, Literature, Music and the Examined Life

A guided tour of the humanities that gives you something real to say in the exam

GST / COMPULSORY

GST & Compulsory Courses

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Humanities questions look broad, so students answer with vague generalities. This pack gives you concrete definitions, examples and evaluation language for literature, visual art, music, theatre and philosophy, plus a method for analysing a work you have never seen before.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Define the humanities and explain why they matter beyond 'self-expression'.
- Analyse a poem, painting, piece of music or play using a repeatable framework.
- Explain the relationship between art, culture and society with Nigerian examples.
- Write a short evaluative answer that makes a claim, gives evidence and acknowledges complexity.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Why the humanities exist

The humanities study human experience and the meanings people make through language, image, sound, performance, belief and argument.

They are not soft subjects. They require close reading, historical context and judgment under uncertainty - the same skills you need to interpret a legal case, a patient's story or a business rumour.

The disciplines you will meet include literature, linguistics, history, philosophy, religious studies, music, theatre and film, and visual arts.

- Literature: how language creates meaning, character and value.
- History: how evidence is selected and interpreted to explain change.
- Philosophy: how concepts and arguments are tested.
- Music and theatre: how performance shapes emotion and community.

Analysing a poem without fear

Use the SOS method: Subject, Occasion, Speaker - then move to form and language.

1. Subject: what is the poem about in one sentence?
2. Occasion: what situation or moment triggered it?
3. Speaker: who is talking, and is it the poet?
4. Form: stanzas, line length, rhyme, rhythm, free verse.
5. Language: diction, imagery, metaphor, simile, personification, repetition.
6. Tone: the speaker's attitude, supported by specific words.
7. Theme: what the poem suggests about life, not just what happens.

> **Avoid the summary trap**
> Retelling the poem is not analysis. Every claim about meaning needs a quotation and a comment on the effect of the language.

Visual art and music as evidence

You do not need to be an artist to analyse art. You need to describe what is there before interpreting it.

- Visual art: subject matter, composition, colour, light, texture, scale, setting, and the artist's likely intention.
- Nigerian reference points: Nok terracotta, Benin bronzes, Igbo uli body painting, contemporary artists such as Ben Enwonwu and Njideka Akunyili Crosby.
- Music: instrument, rhythm, melody, tempo, dynamics, lyrics, call-and-response and context of performance.
- Theatre: script, performance, staging, costume, audience and director's choices.
- Always separate description from interpretation: 'The dominant colour is red' is description; 'The red suggests danger' is interpretation.

Writing an answer that earns marks

Humanities answers are judged on accuracy, evidence and reasoning, not on how emotional they sound.

1. Make a direct claim in the first sentence.
2. Define your key term immediately.
3. Give one concrete example - a text, artwork, event or practice.
4. Explain how the example supports the claim.
5. Add one qualification or counter-point.
6. Close with a sentence that answers the question, not with 'in conclusion'.

> **Useful sentence starters**
> This suggests that... / The choice of... implies... / A limitation of this reading is... / This matters because... Avoid 'it is a very interesting work' with no follow-up.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What is the difference between description and interpretation in art analysis?

Answer: Description states what can be observed (colour, shapes, composition). Interpretation explains what those choices might mean. Interpretation needs descriptive evidence.

2. Name three elements of a poem you would discuss in an analysis.

Answer: Form, imagery and tone are three. You could also discuss diction, rhythm, rhyme or theme, but every claim should be tied to a quotation.

3. Why is the humanities not the same as 'opinion'?

Answer: Humanities scholarship uses evidence, context, method and argument. Opinions can be offered, but they must be supported and open to challenge.

4. Give one Nigerian example of visual art and explain its significance.

Answer: The Benin bronzes are metal plaques and sculptures from the Kingdom of Benin, significant for their craftsmanship and for debates about repatriation of looted heritage.

5. What does 'tone' mean in literary analysis?

Answer: The speaker's attitude toward the subject or audience, revealed through word choice, rhythm and images.

6. How should you discuss a work you have not studied before?

Answer: Describe what is present, identify patterns, connect them to context and make a careful interpretive claim. Do not invent biographical facts.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Read one poem and annotate subject, speaker, form, imagery and tone.
- [ ] Visit a campus exhibition or browse a Nigerian art collection online and describe three works without interpreting them yet.
- [ ] Listen to one Nigerian classical or contemporary piece and write four lines on instrumentation and mood.
- [ ] Write a 250-word answer to 'Why study the humanities?' with two concrete examples.
- [ ] Learn five Nigerian cultural reference points you can use accurately.
- [ ] Analyse a film scene for staging, costume and camera choices.
- [ ] Exchange answers with a coursemate and mark each other for evidence, not length.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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